

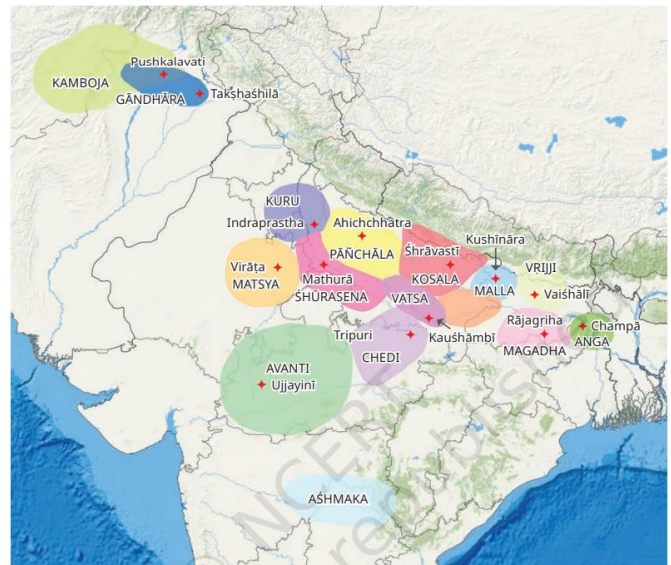
Chapter – 4: New Beginnings: Cities and States

The kingdom shall be protected by fortifying the capital and the towns at the frontiers. The land should not only be capable of sustaining the population but also outsiders in times of calamities. ... It should be beautiful, being endowed with cultivable land, mines, timber forests, elephant forests, and good pastures rich in cattle. It should not depend [only on] rain for water. It should have good roads and waterways. It should have a productive economy, with a wide variety of commodities – Kautilya, Arthaśhāstra

- Early 2nd millennium BCE – Indus / Harappan / Sindhu-Sarasvati civilisation – India's 1st urbanization – disintegrated
- Some cities – abandoned – others – people lived there – BUT – rural lifestyle
- All components – Harappan urban order – disappeared – elaborate structures – private, public – streets, markets – specialized occupations – writing sys. – sanitation sys. – everything
- Whole millennium – urban life – absent from India – a few towns – north India
- 1st millennium BCE – new phase – urbanization – Ganga plains, Indus basin, neighbouring regions
- 2 main sources –
 - Archaeological excavations – confirm existence – ancient urban centres
 - Ancient literature – late Vedic, Buddhist, Jain literature – full of ref.
- New phase – India's Second Urbanization – continued till today

Janapadas and Mahajanapadas

- End – 2nd millennium BCE – regional cultures – reorganized themselves – north India
- People formed clans – share common lang., common customs – each clan – associated to territory (*janapada*) – led by ruler (*raja*)
- *Janapada* – Sanskrit word – where people (*jana*) set foot (*pada*) – settled down
- *Janapadas* – grew – trade expanded – connected them
- 8th – 7th Cent. BCE – some early states – merged together – result – bigger units – *mahajanapadas*
- Most frequent list – 16 *mahajanapadas* – include –
 - Gandhara – northwest
 - Anga – east
 - Ashmaka – central India
- Many more – along with – smaller *janapadas* – independent
- Map – *mahajanapadas*' capitals – most – large fortified cities – moat running outside – further defence
- Often – gateways – rampart walls – kept narrow – guards – control movement – people, goods
- Fascinating – most ancient capitals – continue to be cities today – modern cities – 2500+ yrs. old



Early Democratic Traditions

- Each *janapada* – assembly / council – *sabha* / *samiti* – matters of clan – discussed

- Assume – most members – elders
- *Raja* – not expected – rule independently – good ruler – expected – take advise – assemblies, ministers, administrators
- Some texts – incompetent rulers – removed by assembly
- This thing – significant – BUT – not established law – data – such periods – incomplete
- Political sys. – *mahajanapadas* – expanded – basic principles – *janapadas*
- Some – monarchies – *raja* – ultimate authority – supported by – ministers, assembly of elders
- This position – hereditary – *raja* – son of previous one
- King – collect taxes, maintain order, build fortifications, maintain army
- Magadha, Kosala, Avanti – most powerful
- 2 *mahajanapadas* – Vajji, Malla – diff. sys. – *sabha* – more power – decision – discussion or vote – including selection of *raja*
- *Mahajanapadas* – called – *ganas* or *sanghas* – not monarchies – may be democratic – members of assembly – select ruler, take major decisions
- Scholars – refer them – early republics – earliest sys.

More Innovations

- Age – *janapadas*, *mahajanapadas* – profound change – impact Indian civilisation
- Chapter – India's Cultural Roots (Grade 6) – new schools of thought – Vedic, Buddhist, Jain
- These schools – propagated teachings – scholars, monks, nuns – travelling through India
- Indian art – renewal – blossom – age of empires
- Urbanization – happen with technologies – Harappan civilisation – master – copper, bronze metallurgy
- Second urbanization – major shift – technology – iron metallurgy
- India – several regions – techniques – extracting, shaping iron – perfected – early 2nd millennium BCE – took time – become part – daily life
- Late 2nd millennium BCE – iron tools – widespread – facilitate agriculture
- Iron – better weapons – lighter, sharper – swords, spears, arrows, shields, etc.
- Some evidence – warfare – *mahajanapadas* – frequency, intensity – not known
- These military campaigns – give rise – new kingdoms, empires
- Another innovation – coins – 1st use – India – growing trade
- Very soon – coins – exchanged – diff. regions – even – other parts
- 1st Indian coins – silver made – soft metal – symbols – punched
- Later coins – copper, gold, other metals
- *Mahajanapadas* – issued – own coins – BUT – coins – neighbour regions – used as well

The Varna-Jati System

- Human societies – grow more complex – rise of civilisation
- When this happens – society organises – several grp. – based on – class, occupation, etc.
- Diff. grp. – concerned – governance, administration, religion, education, trade, town-planning, farming, craft, arts – other professions
- Ideal society – all grp. – complement each other – work in harmony
- Most time – these divisions – inequalities – some grp. – acquire wealth, influence – more than others
- Equality – ideal – human societies – very few – achieved it
- India – society – organized – 2-fold sys.

- One category – *jati* – grp. – specific professional occupation – tied to livelihood
- Skills – defined *jati* – agriculture, metallurgy, commerce – generation to generation
- Often – *jati* – further divided – sub-*jati* – customs, traditions – their own – marriage, rituals, food habits
- Along with *jati* – another category – *varna* – concept from Vedic texts
- 4 *varnas* –
 - Brahmins – preserve, spread knowledge – perform rituals
 - Kshatriyas – defend – society, land – engage – warfare
 - Vaishyas – increase society wealth – trade, business, agriculture
 - Shudras – artisans, craftspeople, workers, servants
- Historical evidence – text, inscriptions – early period – people – switch professions – if needed
- Natural calamity – farmers – migrate to city – Brahmins – take up trade, military
- Complex sys. – Indian society – organized cultures – gave some stability
- After some time – sys. – rigid – inequalities, discrimination – lower *jatis* – communities – excluded from *varna-jati* sys.
- *Varna-jati* sys. – deep impact – Indian society – scholars – studied aspects
- Sys. – more flexible – earlier periods – more rigid – later times – specially British rule
- *Varna-jati* – imp. mechanism – BUT – not the only one

Developments Elsewhere in India

- 1st millennium BCE – imp. comm. routes – trade, pilgrimage, military campaigns, etc.
- 2 routes – widely popular – Uttarapatha, Dakshinapatha
- 1st – northwest regions to Ganga plains – upto Eastern India
- 2nd – start from Kaushambi (Prayagraj) – cross capital of *mahajanapadas* – crossed Vindhya Range – proceed to South
- Many lateral roads – connected other parts – specially imp. ports – western, eastern coast – vibrant centres – trade
- Eastern regions – major cities – Shishupalgarh – capital – Kalinga region – square ground plan – fortifications – broad streets
- Southern regions – cities emerged – 400 BCE – recent excavations – claim – signs – commercial act. – further back
- This time – 3 kingdoms – Cholas, Cheras, Pandyas
- Archaeological evidence + most ancient Tamil literature – mention kingdoms, kings
- Southern regions – rich – resources – precious, semi-precious stones, gold, spices – traded – rest of India – kingdoms, empires – overseas
- 300-200 BCE – entire subcontinent – incl. northeast – 1 interconnected land
- Goods, culture – region to region – even beyond India – Central, Southeast Asia
- Same time – *mahajanapadas* – ceased – fresh development – reshape India